MAICON

# FORWARD

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*(AI-Generated Session Notes)*

# Empire of AI: How Silicon Valley is Reshaping the World

**Date & time:** Oct. 15, 8:30-9:15 AM
**Track:** Keynote




## Karen Hao

Award-Winning Journalist and Best-Selling Author of Empire of AI; TIME 100 Most Influential People in AI

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## Paul Roetzer | Q&A Moderator

Founder & CEO, SmarterX & Marketing AI Institute

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## Session Description

In this time of technological and political upheaval, we must re-evaluate the way that we talk about and embrace AI—especially generative models like ChatGPT, and Artificial General Intelligence. Many of the ways that society could benefit from AI—better education and healthcare, a faster transition to renewables, clean air and clean water—have nothing to do with AI models today; they are based on the machine-learning models that have come before.

But Silicon Valley, with OpenAI at its helm, has woven a remarkably compelling narrative about generative AI and Artificial General Intelligence being the key to progress and abundance. This narrative cloaks what's happening beneath the surface, says Karen Hao.

In this timely talk, drawing on years of original research, she examines a growing body of evidence to ask whether AI will ever produce broad-based economic benefit. Companies like OpenAI have become empires in the full sense of the word, consolidating extraordinary power and wealth in the hands of the few. In this historic moment, she shows us, the threat of the empires of AI grows clearer by the day.

A return to empire is the unraveling of democracy. But there is another viable path. Hao offers an ultimately realistic and hopeful look at how to wrestle back what we've already lost, in order to create a world we all want.

## Key Quote

> *"Empires are made to feel inevitable, but history has shown us: when people rise, empires fall."* **- Karen Hao**

## Session Summary

Award-winning journalist Karen Hao, author of Empire of AI, opened the final day of MAICON with a keynote arguing that companies like OpenAI should no longer be viewed simply as businesses selling products and services, but as new forms of empire consolidating historic economic and political power. She began with the story of Alex, a data annotator in Nairobi, Kenya, who was paid roughly $1.46 to $3.74 an hour to read and label violent content used to train the safety filter wrapped around ChatGPT, and who described the nightmares and fear the work left him with. Hao argued his experience was not an anomaly, but the expected consequence of Silicon Valley's "scale at all costs" approach to AI development.

Hao laid out four parallels between the empires of AI and the empires of old: they lay claim to resources that are not their own, such as personal data and intellectual property; they exploit enormous amounts of labor; they monopolize knowledge production by hiring most of the world's AI researchers and controlling what gets published; and they justify their actions with a quasi-religious promise of heaven if they win and hell if a rival does. She noted that both the utopian "boomers" and the "doomers" share the same faith in scaling, which she said is rooted in belief rather than scientific fact.

She then walked through the downstream costs of scaling data and compute: eroding privacy and intellectual property, polluted datasets that require grueling content moderation, a rapidly growing and poorly treated data annotation gig workforce in the U.S., psychological harm tied to engagement-driven chatbots, and the environmental toll of massive data centers. Citing a UN University report, she said data centers used 448 terawatt hours of electricity in 2025, enough to rank 11th among countries, with AI's share of that footprint projected to rise from about 20% to about 40% by 2030. She highlighted communities in Spain, Tucson, and Memphis that are bearing the water and air-quality burdens of new facilities.

Hao's central argument was that this scale is unnecessary. Using a transportation analogy, she described large general-purpose models as "rockets" and called for more "bicycles": small, task-specific, purpose-built systems such as DeepMind's AlphaFold and the climate tools catalogued by the nonprofit Climate Change AI. She pointed to a Māori-language radio station in New Zealand that built a speech transcription model only after securing its community's consent and data donations, and whose models now lead for that language. She closed by urging the audience to see themselves as conscientious technology makers who can shape AI's trajectory, noting that a Tucson coalition succeeded in getting its city council to vote 7–0 to stop an Amazon data center project in its current form.

## Key Takeaways

- **Treat AI labs as empires, not just vendors.** Hao argues that companies like OpenAI claim others' resources, exploit labor, control knowledge production, and justify it all with a moral imperative, consolidating historic economic and political power.

- **Scale carries hidden human and environmental costs.** Aggressively scaling data and compute drives labor exploitation, psychological harm, privacy and IP erosion, and heavy energy and freshwater demands, often in communities that can least afford them.
- **Bigger isn't the only path to capability.** Hao cites research showing the same capabilities can be achieved with significantly less computation, and argues the scaling approach is costing innovation by absorbing capital that could fund other technologies.
- **Build more "bicycles" of AI.** Small, purpose-built systems trained on curated data, like AlphaFold and climate-focused tools, can deliver major benefits without the costs of massive general-purpose models.
- **Consent and community can produce frontier results.** The New Zealand Māori-language project shows that a community-driven, consentful approach can build models that lead for their language.
- **Everyone has a role in shaping AI's trajectory.** Hao urged attendees to act as conscientious technology consumers and makers, pointing to grassroots wins like Tucson's city council vote against an Amazon data center project.

## Q&A

**Q: Knowing what you know about these companies, do you use generative AI yourself?**

**A:** Hao said she does not use generative AI systems from the companies she calls empires, and offered three reasons: she does not want to enable companies whose practices she opposes with her usage or wallet; the core of her work, empathy with sources and compelling writing, is not something AI helps with; and as an investigative reporter she does not want these companies seeing what she is working on. She stressed she is giving people permission not to use it, not condemning those who do, and encouraged everyone to identify what makes their own work valuable and unique.

**Q: If someone wants an alternative to supporting these companies, are open weight models an option?**

**A:** Hao described open weight models as a strong stepping stone toward broadly diffused, purpose-built systems governed by the communities using them. While they were built on the same extractive supply chains, using them means you are not handing your data back to the companies to train the next generation of models. She hopes for fully open source models in the future so scientists can examine the data and better understand and fix the models' problems.

**Q: Since the book came out, have you seen any movement that gives you optimism?**

**A:** Hao said public pressure is shaping company behavior, pointing to OpenAI shuttering its Sora video tool, which she tied to compute constraints connected to data center protests. She also noted that Character AI had just declared bankruptcy following a series of lawsuits sparked by Megan Garcia, and said she is encouraged by more open weight models, wider adoption of them, and more industries using their own expertise to build purpose-built AI.

**Q: Who should people follow to learn more about these challenging issues?**

**A:** Hao recommended the Pulitzer Center's AI Accountability Network, a global network of thousands of journalists in more than 140 countries reporting on AI's impact on communities. Its regular newsletter shares the network's stories and offers nuance beyond the Silicon Valley narrative.